

the flight – before the Americans stopped experimenting with monkeys.

The failure of the rocket's parachute system also caused some other fatalities, including the first mouse in space in 1950.

Meanwhile, the Russians had successfully emulated the V-2 into a new Russian-made rocket called the R1. In 1951, the Soviet Union was the first to send dogs into space. Tsygan and Dezik were launched aboard the R-1 IIIA-1 which not only crossed the 100-km barrier, but also came back without any incident, with both the dogs successfully surviving the spaceflight.

Sputnik

Over the next few years, the Cold War grew more tense and fierce. The space programmes of both, Russia and USA picked up pace and started capturing the world's imagination. It was partly also out of the number of fiction pieces surrounding the subject that aroused people's curiosity.

While each had its own share of great achievements, the Soviet Union was the first to accomplish what both space programmes were created for – the ICBM. In August of 1957, the R-7 Semyorka became the first successful intercontinental ballistic missile and laid the foundation for an even greater accomplishment – the first artificial satellite to orbit the earth.

The story of the artificial satellite actually begins in 1952, when the International Council of Scientific Unions decided to establish July 1, 1957 to December 31, 1958 as the International Geophysical Year (IGY) because the scientists knew that the cycles of solar activity would be at a high point then. In October 1954, the council adopted a resolution calling for artificial satellites to be launched during the IGY to map the Earth's surface.

In July 1955, America announced plans to launch an Earth-orbiting satellite for the IGY and solicited proposals from various Government research agencies to undertake development. In September, it chose and started a project called Vanguard.

But unbeknownst to the US, the Soviets had already started their own plans for the same through a project headed by Sergey Korolev. The Politburo soon announced their own plans to launch an artificial satellite and this formally kicked off the Space Race.

While many expected the Americans to manage to successfully put their own satellite in orbit first, the Russians pipped them to the post.

In 1957, on October 4 at 10:28 p.m. Moscow time, a brilliant and deafening detonation of smoke and flame illuminated the Soviet Union's rocket test site near Tyuratam, Kazakhstan, as the 32 nozzles announced the rise